Causes of the Great War (1871–1914)

KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL & HOMEWORK COMPANION • 40 QUESTIONS

Pupil Name: _____ **Class:** _____ **Teacher:** _____



The Royal Navy battleship HMS Dreadnought (c. 1906–1907) • Revolutionary steam turbine propulsion and ten 12-inch guns triggered the Anglo-German naval arms race.

LESSON UNIT	ATT 1 SCORE	ATT 2 SCORE	RETRIEVAL STRENGTH	PARENT INITIALS
Enquiry 1: German Unification & Revanche *How did German unification and the Franco-Prussian War divide Europe?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 2: Imperial Rivalry & Morocco *How did imperial ambition in Africa bring European powers to the brink of war?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 3: Naval Arms Race & Dreadnought *Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 4: Alliances & Balkan Powder Keg *Did European military alliances protect peace or guarantee a continental catastrophe?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	
Enquiry 5: Sarajevo & The July Crisis *Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite the First World War?*	___ / 8	___ / 8	[ ] Instant [ ] Effortful [ ] Restudy	

● **7–8/8 Mastered:** Secure factual recall. ● **5–6/8 Consolidate:** Flashcard restudy on missed terms. ● **<5/8 Action Required:** Mandatory re-test after DIRT corrections.

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Access online self-marking retrieval flashcards, diagnostic feedback, and audio narration at **the-history-revision-hub.netlify.app**.

1. ► How many independent states existed in Central Europe before German unification?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

2. ► Which powerful military kingdom united the German states under Berlin?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

3. ► Which French border territory was seized by Germany following the Franco-Prussian War in 1871?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

4. ►► What was the French national desire for vengeance against Germany called?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

5. ►► How did Chancellor Otto von Bismarck use "Blood and Iron" to unite Germany?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

6. ►► Why was a "war on two fronts" Germany's greatest strategic nightmare?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

7. ►►► Why did Kaiser Wilhelm II's dismissal of Bismarck in 1890 trigger a European diplomatic crisis?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

8. ►►► How did the creation of the German Empire in 1871 permanently shift the European balance of power?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

9. ► What term describes the rapid colonisation and partition of Africa by European powers (1881–1914)?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

10. ► Which 1884–85 conference laid down international rules for claiming African territory?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

11. ► What famous phrase did Kaiser Wilhelm II use to demand a German global empire?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

12. ►► What was Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive global foreign policy called?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

13. ►► Why did Kaiser Wilhelm II land at Tangier in 1905 to trigger the First Moroccan Crisis?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

14. ►► Why did Germany send the gunboat SMS Panther to Agadir during the 1911 Moroccan Crisis?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

15. ►►► Why did the two Moroccan Crises ironically strengthen rather than weaken the Anglo-French alliance?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

16. ►►► To what extent did imperial rivalry in Africa make a general European war more likely?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

17. ► **Which revolutionary, all-big-gun British battleship was launched in 1906?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

18. ► **Which German Admiral directed the rapid expansion of the German High Seas Fleet?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

19. ► **What long-standing British naval policy required its fleet to equal the next two navies combined?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

20. ►► **Why was naval supremacy a matter of national survival for Great Britain?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

21. ►► **What was Admiral Tirpitz's "Risk Theory" (Risikotheorie)?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

22. ►► **What popular slogan was chanted in Britain in 1909 demanding more battleships?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

23. ►►► **Why did the launch of HMS Dreadnought ironically endanger Britain's established naval supremacy?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

24. ►►► **How did the naval arms race permanently damage relations between Britain and Germany?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

25. Which three empires made up the Triple Alliance signed in 1882? ►

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

26. Which three nations united into the rival Triple Entente by 1907? ►

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

27. ► What mountainous region of south-eastern Europe was known as the "Powder Keg of Europe"?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

28. ►► Why did the decline of the Ottoman Empire create dangerous tension in the Balkans?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

29. ►► Why was Serbia furious when Austria-Hungary annexed Bosnia-Herzegovina in 1908?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

30. Why did Russia feel an ideological duty to support Serbia in Balkan disputes? ►►

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

31. ►►► Why was the Bosnian Crisis of 1908 a fatal rehearsal for the outbreak of war in 1914?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

32. ►►► How did the European alliance system turn a local Balkan confrontation into a world war?

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

33. ► **Who was assassinated in Sarajevo on 28 June 1914?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

34. ► **What was the name of the 19-year-old Bosnian Serb student who fired the fatal shots?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

35. ► **What secret nationalist military society provided the weapons and cyanide for the assassins?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

36. ►► **What unconditional pledge of military backing did Germany give Austria-Hungary on 5 July 1914?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

37. ►► **Why did Austria-Hungary issue Serbia with a harsh 10-point ultimatum on 23 July 1914?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

38. ►► **What German military operational plan aimed to defeat France in six weeks before turning to face Russia?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

39. ►►► **Why did the German invasion of Belgium directly cause Great Britain to enter the war?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

40. ►►► **Was the outbreak of war in 1914 caused primarily by imperial militarism or the rigid mechanics of military mobilisation?**

Answer: _____

Detail: _____

Department Marking Bank • Part 1: Enquiries 1–3 (Q1–Q20)

ENQUIRY 1: GERMAN UNIFICATION & REVANCHE (Q1–Q8)

1. **39 independent states** — Prior to 1871, the German states were loosely connected in the German Confederation, dominated by Prussia and Austria. ►

2. **Prussia** — Prussia used its disciplined military, rail network, and industrial steel power to lead the unification of Germany. ►

3. **Alsace-Lorraine** — Germany annexed this mineral-rich border province, creating an enduring French national desire to reclaim it. ►

4. **Revanche (Revanchism)** — French school maps, veiled in black, and politicians kept the loss of Alsace-Lorraine alive as an open wound. ►►

5. **Through three short, victorious wars and military power rather than democratic speeches** — Bismarck believed grand historical questions were decided by pragmatic military strength (Realpolitik). ►►

6. **It risked being attacked simultaneously by France in the west and Russia in the east** — Germany feared its army would be split in two, leading Bismarck to build alliances to keep Russia neutral. ►►

7. **He abandoned Bismarck's cautious diplomacy and let the Reinsurance Treaty with Russia lapse** — Dropping the treaty left Russia isolated, prompting the Tsar to sign a military alliance with France in 1894. ►►►

8. **It placed a colossal, unified industrial and military giant in the geographic centre of Europe** — The new empire replaced fractured, weak states with an economic powerhouse that rivalled Britain and alarmed France. ►►►

ENQUIRY 2: IMPERIAL RIVALRY & MOROCCO (Q9–Q16)

9. **The Scramble for Africa** — European empires took control of 90% of the African continent to secure raw materials, prestige, and trade markets. ►

10. **The Berlin Conference** — Hosted by Bismarck, it required powers to prove "effective occupation" before claiming colonies to prevent war. ►

11. **A "place in the sun" (Platz an der Sonne)** — Wilhelm II argued that Germany's rapid industrial growth entitled it to an overseas colonial empire equal to Britain's. ►

12. **Weltpolitik ("World Policy")** — Weltpolitik abandoned continental defence in favour of overseas expansion, colonial acquisitions, and naval buildup. ►►

13. **To challenge French influence in North Africa and test the strength of the Anglo-French Entente** — Wilhelm hoped to humiliate France and drive a wedge between Britain and France, but his tactic backfired completely. ►►

14. **To use "gunboat diplomacy" to force France into handing over colonial territory in the Congo** — Germany demanded French land in exchange for accepting French control over Morocco, alarming Britain. ►►

15. **German bullying convinced Britain that Germany was a dangerous rogue state, prompting joint military talks** — Rather than splitting Britain and France, the crises led to secret naval agreements and unified diplomatic resistance. ►►►

16. **It convinced German leaders they were encircled by hostile rivals and normalised armed brinkmanship** — Repeated colonial confrontations conditioned European publics to expect war and deepened military planning. ►►►

ENQUIRY 3: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT (Q17–Q20)

17. **HMS Dreadnought** — Dreadnought carried ten 12-inch guns and turbine engines, rendering all existing battleships instantly obsolete. ►

18. **Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz** — Tirpitz passed the German Naval Laws (1898/1900) to build a navy capable of confronting Britain in the North Sea. ►

19. **The Two-Power Standard** — Britain considered unquestioned naval mastery essential to guard its worldwide trade routes and island food supply. ►

20. **As an island empire, Britain relied on maritime trade for raw materials and to feed its population** — A hostile blockade would starve Britain within months, making any threat to the North Sea intolerable. ►►

Department Marking Bank • Part 2: Enquiries 3–5 (Q21–Q40)

ENQUIRY 3: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT (Q21–Q24)

21. **Building a fleet strong enough that fighting Germany would cripple Britain's global supremacy** — Tirpitz calculated that fear of naval damage would force Britain to make diplomatic and colonial concessions.

22. **"We want eight and we won't wait!"** — Public alarm over secret German shipbuilding forced the British government to double its naval construction budget.

23. **It wiped out Britain's enormous numerical lead in older pre-dreadnoughts, resetting the race to zero** — By making existing warships obsolete, Germany could compete on equal terms by building only new dreadnoughts.

24. **It turned friendly trading partners into suspicious military rivals and drove Britain toward France and Russia** — German naval expansion convinced British statesmen that Germany aimed to dominate Europe by military force.

ENQUIRY 4: ALLIANCES & BALKAN POWDER KEG (Q25–Q32)

25. **Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy** — The members promised mutual military assistance if attacked by two or more rival great powers.

26. **Great Britain, France, and Russia** — Agreements between France, Russia, and Britain settled past disputes and formed a defensive diplomatic counterweight.

27. **The Balkans** — Ethnic nationalism, crumbling Ottoman rule, and great power rivalry made the Balkans extremely volatile.

28. **It left a power vacuum that Austria-Hungary and Russia both competed to dominate** — Both empires sought influence over newly independent Balkan states and control of the Black Sea straits.

29. **Bosnia contained a large Slavic population that Serbia wanted to unite into an independent South Slav state** — The annexation frustrated Serbian nationalist dreams of creating a united "Greater Serbia".

30. **Russia viewed itself as the natural protector of fellow Slavic and Orthodox Christian peoples** — Russian "Pan-Slavism" and the desire for warm-water Mediterranean access drove its alliance with Serbia.

31. **Russia was forced to back down under German threats, vowing never to retreat in the Balkans again** — The humiliation accelerated Russian military rearmament and ensured Russia would mobilise if Serbia was threatened.

32. **It chained the great powers together so that an attack on one ally triggered mandatory mobilization of all** — The treaties transformed a local conflict between Austria and Serbia into an uncontrollable continental domino effect.

ENQUIRY 5: SARAJEVO & THE JULY CRISIS (Q33–Q40)

33. **Archduke Franz Ferdinand (heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne)** — His assassination during an official inspection tour provided the immediate catalyst for the outbreak of war.

34. **Gavrilo Princip** — Princip was a member of Young Bosnia, trained and armed by the Serbian nationalist secret society, the Black Hand.

35. **The Black Hand (Unity or Death)** — Led by Serbian military intelligence officer Dragutin Dimitrijević ("Apis"), the group aimed to liberate South Slavs.

36. **The "Blank Cheque"** — Kaiser Wilhelm II promised German military support even if Austrian action against Serbia triggered war with Russia.

37. **To provide a pretext for military invasion and permanently crush Serbian independence** — Austrian leaders drafted demands so humiliating that they expected Serbia to reject them, justifying war.

38. **The Schlieffen Plan** — The plan relied on invading neutral Belgium to bypass French border fortresses and encircle Paris rapidly.

39. **Britain had guaranteed Belgian neutrality in the 1839 Treaty of London and could not accept hostile ports on the Channel** — When Germany refused to respect Belgian neutrality, Britain delivered an ultimatum and declared war on 4 August 1914.

40. **A fatal combination of calculated risk-taking by leaders and inflexible rail mobilisation timetables** — Once Tsar Nicholas II ordered general mobilisation, German war plans left zero time for diplomatic negotiation.